him, Kallis will always be king. Innings after innings, tour after tour, season after season, he was a model of consistent brilliance.

Beyond the numbers, he was quiet, relaxed and always approachable. Never the kind of person who would walk up to you and presume to tell you what you were doing wrong, he was always open, receptive and sympathetic to anyone who sought his help and advice.

Jacques became my fixer. In tough times, when it felt as though I couldn't score a run and I couldn't understand what I was doing wrong, in those lonely and confusing times, I would seek his advice and he would always respond, giving me the benefit of his time, his knowledge and his experience.

It is June 2007 ... and the South African team is playing against India and Ireland in a triangular tournament called the Future Cup in Northern Ireland. We are playing an Indian team depleted by illness and led by Rahul Dravid at the Civil Service ground near Stormont, and I am not in a good place at all.

With only two half-centuries in my previous 14 ODI innings, I am opening the innings with Morné van Wyk and, to be blunt, I feel completely out of touch. Zaheer Khan opens the bowling with a maiden to Morné, leaving me to face the second over from RP Singh. A mistimed glance, a rushed block deep in the crease, left alone, an inside edge squirting to square leg, a tame drive played and missed, a block ... another maiden over; we are 0–0 after two.

It's difficult to exaggerate the agony of a batsman who is out of touch, hard to explain how the art of batting – which can seem so easy and natural when everything is going well – can suddenly be transformed into something that is not just challenging but feels truly impossible. You stand there, concentrating on your stance, your grip, your backlift, focusing on everything and nothing, and every ball looks like a hand grenade.